

Morongo Unified School District
Adhoc Board Committee
School Enrollment and 7-11 Surplus Property Committee
2025 - 2026

Committee Report and Recommendations

Committee Chairperson: Jennifer Cusack

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MORONGO UNIFIED SCHOOL DISTRICT

Enrollment/7-11 Advisory Committee

Report and Recommendations to the Board of Education

May 2026

I. Committee Charge

In response to a sustained period of enrollment decline across the Morongo Unified School District (MUSD), the Board of Education authorized the formation of the Enrollment/7-11 Advisory Committee in December 2025. The Committee was formally convened in January 2026 following a competitive application and selection process open to parents, community members, and district staff.

The Committee was charged with the following responsibilities:

- Review current and projected student enrollment data across all district school sites, with particular focus on elementary-level trends.
- Evaluate school facility conditions, site capacities, and the efficient utilization of district resources.
- Consider the potential impacts of school consolidation, facility upgrades, boundary adjustments, and large-scale programmatic changes on students, families, and the broader community.
- Identify school sites, if any, that may be considered surplus or underutilized property, and make recommendations regarding the potential use of such properties.
- Develop and present formal recommendations to the Board of Education to guide decision-making in response to declining enrollment and associated fiscal impacts.

Throughout its work, the Committee was guided by the principle that any recommended changes must center the educational needs and well-being of students while reflecting the unique geographic, demographic, and community characteristics of the Morongo Basin. The district engaged School Leaders, as a professional consulting firm to provide data analysis, facilitation support, and technical expertise throughout the process.

The Committee's recommendations are advisory in nature. Final decisions regarding school consolidation, closure, or property designation rest with the Board of Education.

II. Committee Membership

The Committee is composed of community members, parents, and district staff who were selected to ensure broad representation across the Morongo Basin. At the inaugural meeting held on January 26, 2026, members elected the following officers:

Role	Name	Affiliation / Role
Chairperson	Jennifer Cusack	Parent & Community Representative
Vice Chairperson	Karla Buchanan	District Administrator Community Representative
Member	Krystal Conrad	Environment and Building Parent & Community Representative
Member	Nicole Hitch	Parent & Community Representative
Member	Jeff Brady	Business Representative
Member	Daniel Ramon Iniguez	Community Representative
Member	Wayne Hamilton	District Employee Community Representative
Member	Amanda Mayes	Teacher Community Representative
Member	Sara Smith	District Employee Parent & Community Representative

District staff and administration, including Superintendent Dr. Patricio Vargas, Assistant Superintendent of Elementary Education Dr. Gracie Gutierrez, Assistant Superintendent Business Services David Daniels, and Public Information Officer Jene Estrada participated in Committee meetings in a support and informational capacity. Information was provided to the committee by the District's architect, demographer and attorney. Representatives from School Leaders, led by consultant Dr. Stella Kemp, facilitated the process and provided data presentations throughout the Committee's work.

III. Information Reviewed by the Committee

Over the course of its meetings, the Committee reviewed a comprehensive body of data, reports, and community input to ensure that its recommendations are grounded in evidence and reflect the interests of all stakeholders. The following categories of information were presented and discussed:

A. Enrollment and Demographic Data

- Historical enrollment trends spanning the past decade, showing a decline from approximately 10,000 students at the district's peak to approximately 7,300 students in the 2025-26 school year.
- Current enrollment figures by school site, including individual campus enrollment counts and school capacity data.
- Five-year enrollment projections prepared by the District's demographer, SchoolWorks, Inc., which estimate that district enrollment could decline to approximately 6,821 students within five years absent any initiatives to increase enrollment.
- Updated demographic data presented in February 2026, including birth rate trends, population shifts, and regional demographic projections affecting the Morongo Basin.
- Analysis of enrollment patterns by geographic area within the district.

B. Facilities Assessment

- A comprehensive assessment of current school facility conditions at each district site, including building age, infrastructure condition, capacity utilization, and deferred maintenance needs.
- The district's 2024 Facilities Master Plan.
- Capacity analysis identifying schools operating significantly below enrollment capacity alongside those that could absorb additional students.
- Site visit reports from Committee members who conducted in-person tours of school campuses to evaluate physical conditions firsthand.

C. Financial and Operational Data

- The district's 2025-26 Second Interim Budget, which reflects a core operating deficit of approximately \$7 million, with approximately \$4 million in structural deficit after accounting for one-time expenditures.
- Explanation of the state's Average Daily Attendance (ADA) funding model, including the fiscal impact of low-enrollment campuses that require subsidy from district-wide resources, and state funding including information related to rural school funding.
- Per-site cost analysis and information on how enrollment funding is spread across multiple campuses.
- Transportation cost data and the potential impacts of boundary adjustments and school closures on busing routes and expenses.
- Staffing ratios for special education students and information on class size implications under various consolidation scenarios.

D. Consolidation and Boundary Scenarios

- The demographer's report, prepared in Fall 2025 and updated Spring 2026, provided an initial analysis of the district's enrollment and facilities challenges and identified potential consolidation opportunities, including Morongo Valley and Friendly Hills elementary schools.
- Five consolidation scenarios presented by Superintendent Vargas at the April 9, 2026 meeting, ranging from no school closures to the closure of up to three campuses (Palm Vista, Landers, and Morongo Valley elementary schools).
- Analysis of how boundary adjustments could rebalance enrollment across existing campuses as an alternative or complement to closures.
- Discussion of Joshua Tree Elementary School as a potential expanded TK-8 magnet campus given its capacity and the condition of its facilities.

E. Community and Stakeholder Input

- A community survey distributed to families and community members throughout the Morongo Basin, with results reviewed by the Committee. (Note: Committee members raised concerns about the survey methodology, including the potential for duplicate submissions.)
- Public testimony received during the public comment periods at all Committee meetings, including input from parents, teachers, and community advocates representing campuses across the district.

- Perspectives from staff, parents, students and community members at schools discussed for potential closure, including Landers, Friendly Hills, Morongo Valley, and Palm Vista elementary schools.

IV. Meeting Dates and Summaries

The Committee held seven public meetings between January and May 2026, all beginning at 6:00 p.m. at the Joshua Tree Professional Development Center (former Joshua Tree Elementary School), 6061 Sunburst Street, Joshua Tree, California, unless otherwise noted. All meetings were open to the public and included a public comment period.

Date	Location	Summary
January 26, 2026	JT Professional Development Center	Inaugural meeting. Committee members were introduced and organizational business was conducted. Jennifer Cusack was elected Chair and Karla Buchanan was elected Vice Chair. District staff and School Leaders provided an overview of the committee's charge, process, and timeline. Members received an initial orientation to the demographer's report and district enrollment trends.
February 18, 2026	JT Professional Development Center	The Committee received a presentation on updated district demographics and historical enrollment trends, including projections showing continued decline. A detailed assessment of current school facility conditions across all district sites was presented by the district's architect. Members reviewed facility capacity data and began discussing the relationship between enrollment, facility utilization, and district resources.
February 21, 2026	JT Professional Development Center	The Committee members participated in a district-led tour of all elementary schools, except Condor Elementary. They were supported by district staff and representatives from School Leaders along with the District's architect.

March 4, 2026	JT Professional Development Center	The Committee continued its review of enrollment data and began developing a framework to guide potential future recommendations. Members raised questions about the scope of the committee's work, asking when alternatives to school closure—such as boundary adjustments—would be explored. Staff agreed to provide additional information on busing costs, boundary maps, special education staffing ratios, and class sizes.
April 9, 2026	JT Professional Development Center	The committee heard five consolidation scenarios ranging from no school closures to the closure of up to three campuses. The scenarios included various boundary adjustments and a proposal to expand Joshua Tree Elementary into a TK-8 magnet school. Members continued developing the criteria framework that would be used to evaluate school sites and inform recommendations.
April 29, 2026	JT Professional Development Center	The Committee received the Second Interim Budget update, including presentation of the district's financial position and deficit projections. An educational program overview was presented. Members reviewed their individual site analyses and began working toward consensus on recommended actions. Discussion and agreement was reached regarding elementary school consolidation and boundary recommendations, Legal counsel provided information regarding surplus property designation, and the committee postponed the discussion regarding the surplus property designation until the next meeting.
May 13, 2026	JT Professional Development Center	The Committee met to finalize and take action to forward the consolidation report to the Board of Education for the June 9, 2026 Board meeting.

V. School Consolidation Recommendation

In light of the District's proposed budget stabilization efforts, the Committee respectfully requests that the Board initiate comprehensive measures to achieve alternative fiscal efficiencies as outlined in the recommendations from the April 2026 Budget Stabilization Report prior to considering the closure of any school campuses.

Following an exhaustive evaluation of enrollment projections, school facility assessments, financial data, stakeholder input, and various consolidation scenarios, the Morongo Unified School District Enrollment/7-11 Advisory Committee submits the following formal recommendations for Board consideration:

1. The Committee recommends adjusting school boundaries across the Morongo Unified School District to better balance elementary school enrollment throughout the district.
2. The Committee affirms school closures should remain a measure of last resort due to their lasting impact on students, families, staff, as well as the broader community. Before pursuing irreversible actions such as school closures, the district should demonstrate that all viable enrollment, retention, and operational efficiency strategies have been fully implemented and evaluated. Therefore, the Committee recommends that MUSD refrain from closing any schools and instead prioritize the implementation of alternative cost-saving and enrollment recovery strategies, including but not limited to:
 - Conducting targeted outreach to families residing within MUSD boundaries who are currently enrolled in online charter schools, faith-based schools, or other alternative educational programs, with the goal of re-engaging and returning students to the district.
 - Strengthening the district's Multi-Tiered System of Supports (MTSS) by expanding academic, behavioral, and social-emotional interventions and services. A more robust MTSS framework can improve student outcomes, increase attendance, strengthen student retention, and positively impact district revenue.
 - Expanding and strategically investing in the district's existing Independent Study Program, ACCE, to establish it as a flagship educational offering within MUSD. This includes ensuring the program is fully supported, thoughtfully developed, and intentionally marketed to families seeking flexible and innovative public education options. A strong and well-resourced Independent Study program increases enrollment, improves student retention, provides meaningful alternatives for families considering leaving the district, and positions MUSD as a leader in innovative and responsive public education.
3. Formalizing advocacy for changes to school funding mechanisms at the state level, including revisions to Average Daily Attendance (ADA) funding and expanded eligibility for rural school funding. Including pursuing state-level outreach to address inconsistencies between education code requirements and the practical needs of educational programs. These efforts are intended to better account for districts such as Morongo Unified School District, which, despite their large geographic boundaries, continue to serve distinct rural school communities.

The Committee respectfully requests that the Board of Education carefully consider these recommendations and ensure that any decisions made are accompanied by clear implementation timelines, transparent community communication, and a plan to monitor the impact of changes on student outcomes and community well-being.

The Committee acknowledges that any recommendation regarding school consolidation must carefully weigh the educational, fiscal, community, and equity implications of the proposed changes. Members have endeavored to approach this work with diligence, fairness, and a genuine commitment to the students and families of the Morongo Basin.

Respectfully submitted on behalf of the Morongo Unified School District Enrollment/7-11
Advisory Committee,

Jennifer Cusack, Chairperson
MUSD Enrollment/7-11 Advisory Committee
May 13, 2026